

Kiribati

Ratio: 1:2 **Adopted:** July 12, 1979 **Usage:** National and Civil

The red shield in the coat of arms also depicts a gold flying frigate bird above a rising golden sun



The frigate bird symbolizes command of the sea

The blue and white wavy bands represent the Pacific Ocean

Australasia and Oceania



Once part of the British colony of the Gilbert and Ellice Islands, the Gilberts became independent in 1979 and adopted the name **Kiribati**.

Kiribati's flag is one of only three national flags which are armorial banners—flags having a design which corresponds exactly to that of the shield in the coat of arms.

ARMS OF KIRIBATI

The coat of arms dates back to May 1937 when it was granted to the Gilbert and Ellice Islands, as Kiribati and Tuvalu were then known. The shield, was then incorporated into the center of the fly half of a British Blue Ensign as the state ensign of the colony.

Shortly before independence was granted in 1979, a local competition was held to choose a new national flag and a design based on the

colonial coat of arms, was submitted to the College of Arms. The College of Arms decided to modify the design. Both the golden frigate bird and the sun were enlarged to occupy more of the top of the flag and the width of the blue and white wavy bands was reduced.

THE ORIGINAL DESIGN

However, the local people insisted on the original design, in which the top and bottom halves of the flag were equal, the sun and local frigate bird small, and the various design elements outlined in black.

The new flag was hoisted during the independence day celebrations in the capital, Tarawa on July 12, 1979.